

Unreliable communication

In the UK press, the early part of summer is often called the silly season. And there I was not realising this also applied in India. I had heard more than a couple of times people joke that Reliance Communications was named ironically, because the company's service is anything but reliable, but this did not stop me trying out the company's new offering – a USB broadband system, said to be capable of up to 3.1 Mbps. After all, my own local internet provider in Delhi – the entertainingly named “World Impulse Network” – is awful.

It goes off-line just about every day, often more than once, and sometimes for several hours. I often have to call them up perhaps 20 times in order to get them even to answer a phone, and when I get through, very often I get somebody apparently not able to hear me: “Hello ... hello ... hello...” Shouting very loud and angrily sometimes switches this into a slightly better form of communication. The internet magically starts again, and then it rains. Internet off again. So, I have a strong incentive to find a decent service provider for myself, and our readers might well be interested in this new Reliance system. After all, what could be worse than my local provider? You guessed it right...

I contacted Reliance and told them that not only did I want to investigate this and write it up for *Digit*, but that I might take it up myself and become a real customer.

A neat USB stick arrived, was installed in my desktop PC and then my laptop, and it worked for a couple of days – and then stopped. I tried calling a couple of contacts in Reliance a few times, I emailed the original contacts – all to no avail. It continued not to work. At one point I was told that the device would be replaced that afternoon, but this did not happen.

After about six weeks of zero service, I was telephoned by somebody in Reliance to ask how I was getting on with the system! I told him in no uncertain terms, and the response was that some people have good experiences and some have bad! And I thought P.R. was bad in the UK. What a good way to get a contract signed! Then, a few days later, when I was at our office one day, two people turned up at my flat to collect the device. My wife called me and passed the phone to these chaps. I asked if they wanted me “to tell all our readers that this service is total rubbish and simply does not work?” They left, apparently grinning broadly.

Apart from the breathtaking and boneheaded incompetence of these people, there is one serious point that arose when I looked into this system from Reliance – it involves a cap on the quantity of material that you can download. The most attractive scheme that I could find entailed a cap of 10 GBs per month. This ensured that I would never sign up to such a scheme, even if the system had worked perfectly all the time I was trying it out. I would not recommend anybody else to do so – apart from people who just want to do a little email from time to time. But why would they need a fast connection? For everybody else, 10 GB is very little – a joke.

This capping – and I am told that Reliance is not the only company trying such a scam – is an attempt at irresponsible profiteering. One question that I was unable to get answered with the Reliance system was how I would determine my usage at any point in time – when have I just gone over, say, nine GB, so that I know now to slow down? I have heard stories of people being shocked at the painful bills they receive having inadvertently gone over their cap limits.

This policy misses the whole point of broadband systems. People that want broadband are likely to want to download more material, and anyway, this is not always voluntary. Many websites are increasingly using “rich content” and you can often find yourself on a page with a couple of videos playing, when you have just come to read a small news item. And those videos are eating away your cap allowance for the month. Does Reliance want to encourage internet use, or strangle it?

These caps have been tried in other countries, and when I first used a broadband system in the UK, it was capped. But the cap was never imposed and was later withdrawn – customers just would not put up with such a silly system. I hope people here resist it as much as possible.



Edward Henning, Editor-in-Chief

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A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "E. Henning".

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